

MOVIE

The Irishman

★★★★☆ | This is probably the last time we'll ever get to witness the greats in their last ever crime epic. Much like most of Martin Scorsese's other works, *The Irishman* has a slow and steady pace as it chronicles the life of Frank Sheeran who allegedly was a hitman for the Bufalino crime family and was even alleged to have been involved in the disappearance of Jimmy Hoffa, an extremely influential labour union leader from the '50s to the '60s. At 209 minutes, the movie is undoubtedly longer than most traditional movies but for fans of epic crime dramas, there isn't a dull moment.

Joe Pesci came out of retirement to play Russel Bufalino, a mob boss and mentor to Robert De Niro's Frank Sheeran. We get to relive moments



from Frank Sheeran's life as he recounts his entire life from the moment he was a just lowly truck driver to getting noticed by the local mob bosses and then becoming a close confidant

of Jimmy Hoffa who is played by Al Pacino towards the latter half of the movie. *The Irishman* isn't as action-packed as Scorsese's previous mafia movies but there's enough to send a chill down your spine as you see Frank assassinate his targets like a loyal soldier of an Italian mafia family. The movie makes considerable use of VFX for de-aging the actors but it's been done in a limited fashion and only when absolutely required. In fact, Industrial Light and Magic had to create a new method of deaging which did not require markers to be placed on the actors during production.

The Irishman didn't see a wide theatrical release as it was distributed by Netflix but considering the slew of award nominations and rave reviews the movie has received, it seems certain that Netflix has easily made good on the production costs. Perhaps, this is a sign of times to come as theatres take a back seat and direct-to-TV is no longer an insult.

TV SERIES

The Mandalorian

★★★★☆ | Disney money spent right. Even if you haven't watched *The Mandalorian*, you'll no doubt have come across the adorable Baby Yoda through a gallore of memes, even though it isn't actually Yoda given that *The Mandalorian* takes place between Episodes VI and VII. *The Mandalorian* is very much what the original trilogy set out to be, a space-spaghetti-western with elements of mysticism.

Unlike the episodes that followed and changed the dynamic of the entire saga, *The Mandalorian* stays true to the ethos of the original trilogy while evolving to keep up with the times. Moreover, the focus shift from the central characters to one of the side characters and then making the audience relate to them is something that



The Mandalorian pulls off wonderfully. The series features strong characters and spends ample amount of time developing their backstories. Each episode progresses at a rather comfortable pace and expands some of the lore around the Mandalorian creed. The story doesn't dwell much on the

protagonists' past and instead we are treated with flashbacks that piece together the puzzle that is "Mando".

You can thank the stellar folks that are at the helm for the great production quality. For one, this is one of the first franchises that Disney+ is heavily banking upon to build a user base and then there are the producers and writers who are stars in their own right. Jon Favreau has built quite the repertoire of directing big budget movies with elements of science-fiction and he certainly has a keen eye for detail with bringing characters who already have a massive following to life. Bring in Dave Filoni's writing chops along with his experience of having worked on multiple IPs set within the Star Wars Universe and you have a guaranteed formula for success.

Sure, Disney is going to make billions off some Baby Yoda merch but for fans of the extended universe, that has been in the development for the past four decades, *The Mandalorian* is a series that fits to be in every SW fan's collection.